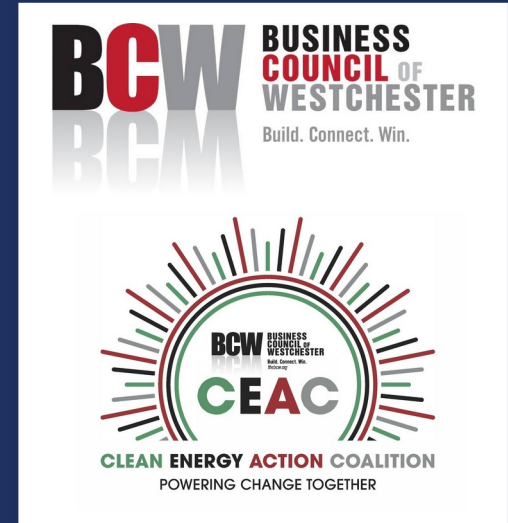


Battery Energy Storage: A Guide For Westchester's Local Leaders

A briefing for municipal boards, committees, and local decision makers. Capturing the benefits of battery storage, with safety as the top priority.

Prepared by the BCW Clean Energy Action Coalition • 2026



Battery storage unit by Sprocket Power at Vail GMC,
Bedford Hills

WHO WE ARE

Introduction to CEAC



BCW's Clean Energy Action Coalition

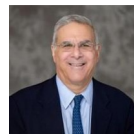


130 coalition members across Westchester: businesses, nonprofits, municipalities, and institutions working together on the clean energy transition.



Dr. Marsha Gordon

President & CEO, Business Council of Westchester



John Ravitz

EVP & COO, Business Council of Westchester



Noam Bramson

EVP, Government Affairs & Economic Development, BCW



Ron Kamen

Co-Founder & Program Director, CEAC | Founder, EarthKind Energy

WHY WE'RE HERE

Help municipalities capture the benefits of battery storage while keeping safety the top priority.

THE BASICS

What Is Battery Energy Storage (BESS)?

BESS saves electricity for when it's needed most. It charges when power is cheap and abundant, and delivers it during peak demand: hot summer afternoons and evenings.



Small (Tier 1): 10 to 80 kWh

Homes and small businesses. Footprint: the size of a small refrigerator.



Medium: under 600 kWh

Commercial backup and demand management. Footprint: one parking space.

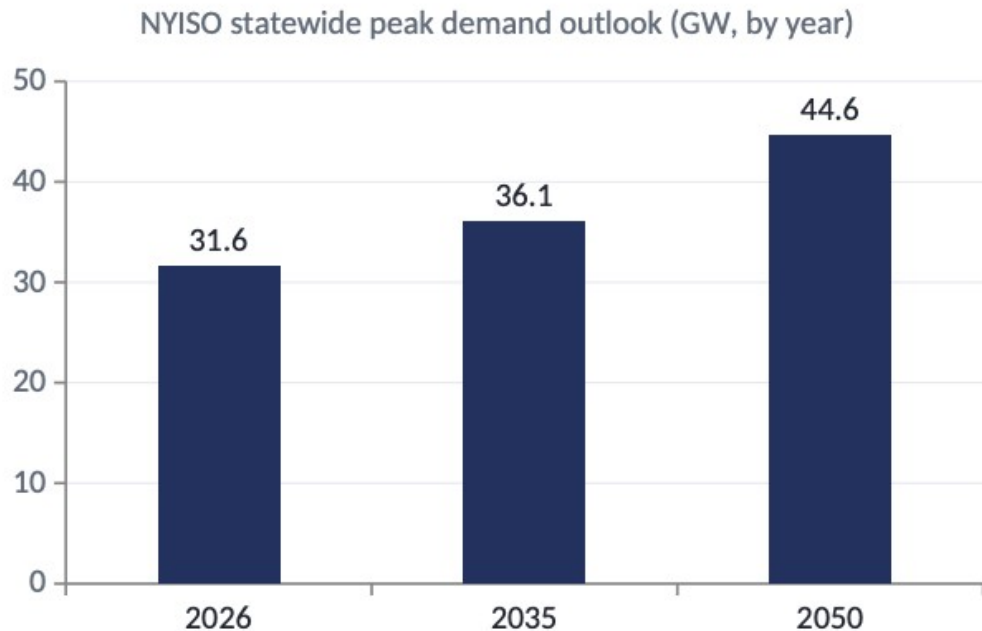


Large (Tier 2): over 600 kWh

Grid support and community energy storage. Footprint: about half an acre.

Photos and sizing: NYSEDA Energy Storage Program. Tier 1 / Tier 2 distinction from NY's model law.

Reliability: Demand Is Rising Fast



Source: NYISO 2026 load forecast and long-term outlook (Gold Book / Power Trends 2026). 2035 interpolated.

Power at peak demand

BESS delivers stored power during the highest-demand hours, reducing stress on the local grid.

Fewer outages

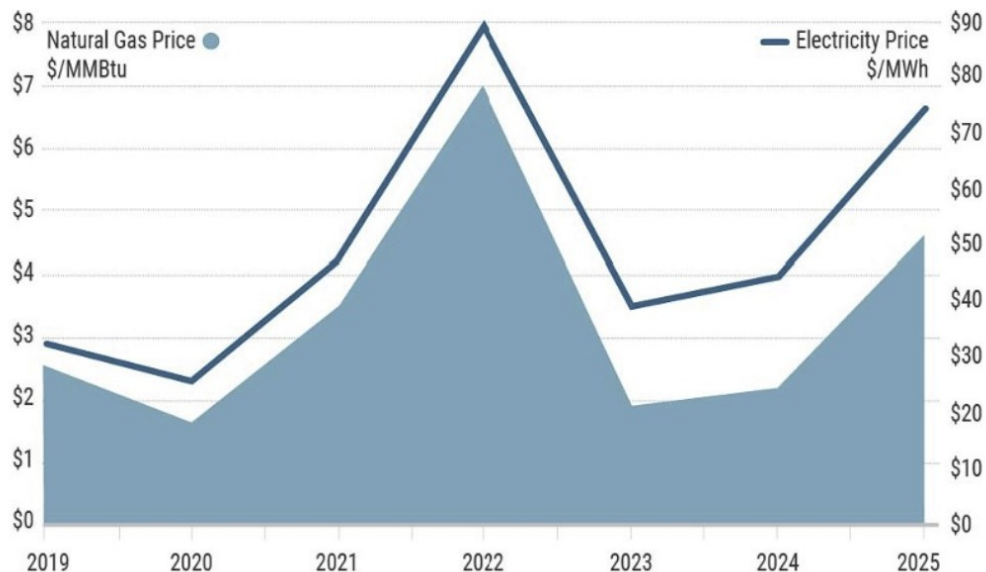
BESS lowers overload and outage risk in constrained areas of the grid.

Electrification is coming

Homes, vehicles, heating, and cooling are electrifying, so reliability matters more every year.

Affordability: Our Bills Track Natural Gas

Figure 1: Average Gas and Electricity Prices in New York: 2019-2025



Average gas (\$/MMBtu, left) and electricity (\$/MWh, right) prices in New York, 2019 to 2025. Data: NYSERDA / NYISO, via CEAC reference materials.



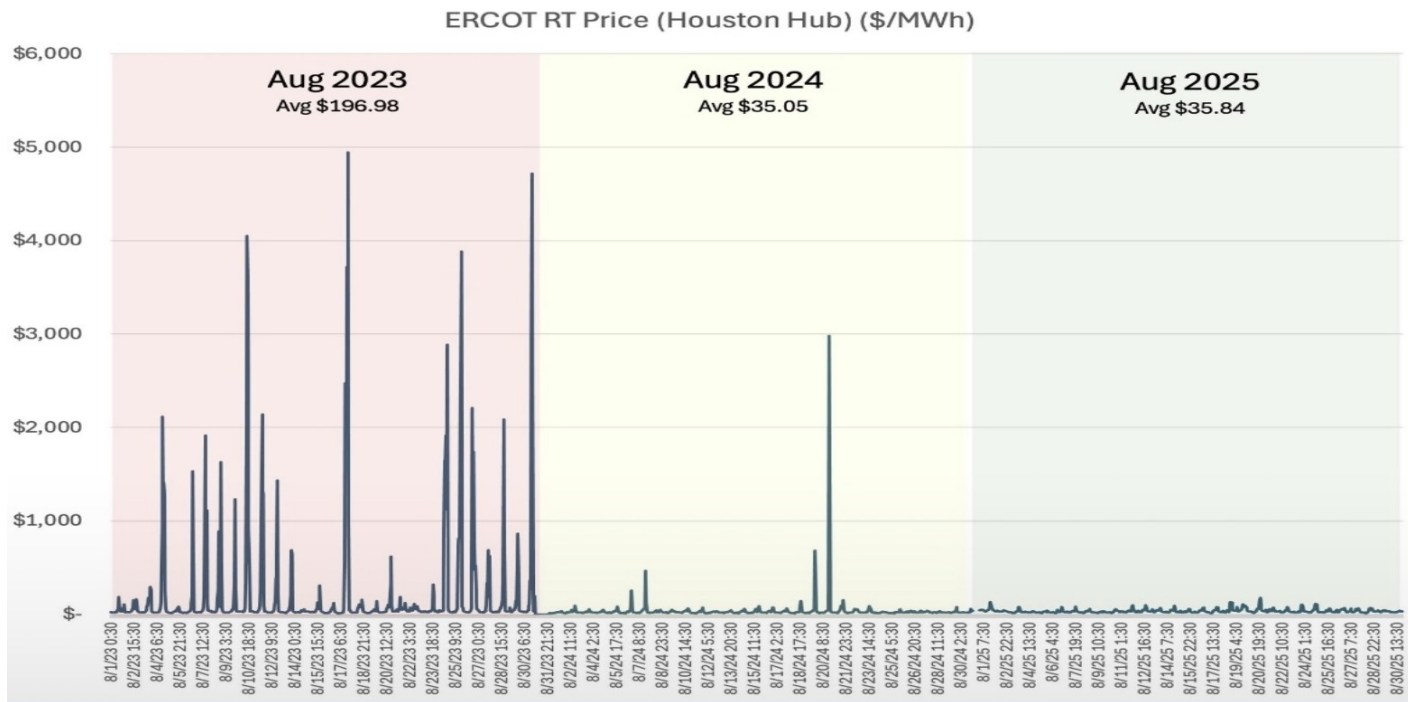
Since 2022, typical Con Edison residential rates are up about 30%: from just over 30 cents per kWh to over 40 cents. The winter 2025-26 gas spike hit bills within weeks.



Peak hours cost the most

Cuts use of the costliest peak power, older fossil peaker plants, and buffers bills against gas price swings. NYC ratepayers paid \$4.5B over a decade just keeping 16 fossil peakers on standby.

Texas: Demand met by cheap renewables + storage



Local solar + BESS breaks the link

Locally generated and stored clean power cuts exposure to gas price volatility and shaves the most expensive peak hours.

Solar Needs Storage.



Solar + storage work together

Paired with solar, storage saves locally produced clean power for when it's most useful.



Renewables are intermittent

The sun sets and the wind calms. Batteries turn intermittent generation into dependable power.



Solar + storage = affordability

Solar saved New Yorkers about \$90M in peak-hour costs last summer alone. Storage makes that clean power available at the evening peak.



Croton-Harmon Station: solar, BESS, and EV charging in Westchester

Environmental Advocates Strongly Support BESS.

Natural Resources Defense Council (NRDC)

"Battery storage may be the only way that utilities, states, and industry leaders keep up with data center demand and alleviate skyrocketing prices."

— **Claire Lang-Ree**, Advocate, Sustainable FERC Project (Climate & Energy), and **Tom Rutigliano**, Senior Advocate (Climate & Energy), NRDC

Source <https://www.nrdc.org/bio/claire-lang-ree/unlocking-storage-solution-data-center-strain>

"Storage offers us a terrific opportunity to partner with renewable energy resources to build a cleaner and more effective electric grid."

— **Elizabeth Noll**, (former NRDC staff) and **Arjun Krishnaswami**, NRDC — "Energy Storage: A Critical Player in a Cleaner Grid," July 17, 2018

Source <https://www.nrdc.org/bio/elizabeth-noll/energy-storage-critical-player-cleaner-grid>

Environmental Defense Fund (EDF)

"With batteries, there's no need for either overproduction or inefficient backup reserves, ultimately saving both utilities and customers money."

— **Dick Munson**, Environmental Defense Fund — Energy Exchange blog, Oct 27, 2014

Source <https://blogs.edf.org/energyexchange/2014/10/27/disruptive-is-a-buzzwordbut-its-true-for-batteries/>

New York League of Conservation Voters (NYLCV)

"Battery storage is key to ensuring the reliability of our electric grid and to shutting down dirty power plants that pollute our communities."

— **Pat McClellan**, Policy Director, New York League of Conservation Voters — Feb 2024

Source <https://www.nylcv.org/news/battery-energy-storage-systems-a-clean-energy-solution-ny-needs/>

"BESS is safe, reliable, and highly regulated. The real danger? Sticking with fossil fuels that come with unpredictable costs, worsen air pollution, and increase the risk of power outages."

— **Georgia Good**, Communications Fellow, NYLCV — NYLCV Education Fund, Mar 31, 2026

Source <https://nylcvef.org/citizens-toolkit/the-power-of-battery-energy-storage-systems/>

"Modern BESS facilities are safe, reliable, and strictly regulated with oversight under New York's nation-leading building codes. These projects support local communities and economies by creating good-paying jobs, generating tax revenue, and strengthening the grid."

— **New York League of Conservation Voters**

Source <https://actions.nylcv.org/a/bess-reli>

Sierra Club

"The concerns regarding a lack of safety where BESS is concerned are unfounded and misleading. The risks associated with a BESS installation as compared to peaker plants and other fossil fuel burning energy plants are minimal."

— **Sierra Club**, Atlantic Chapter — Mid-Hudson Group, organizational statement

Source <https://www.sierraclub.org/atlantic/mid-hudson/battery-energy-storage-systems-bess>

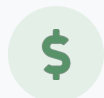
Alliance for Clean Energy New York (ACE NY)

"Energy storage will provide many benefits to a modern power grid, including the ability to fully harness our most cost-effective energy solutions in wind and solar."

— **Marguerite Wells**, Executive Director, Alliance for Clean Energy New York — July 28, 2025

Source <https://www.governor.ny.gov/news/governor-hochul-announces-first-bulk-energy-storage-solicitation-part-new-yorks-energy-storage>

Why Should Westchester's Leaders Care?



Revenue

Local tax revenue and PILOT payments, lease income for host property owners, construction and maintenance jobs, and infrastructure that strengthens the local electric system.



Consumer benefit

Community solar subscribers see bill savings, and paired BESS increases the value of that local clean energy. Homeowners and businesses increasingly want storage: empower them.



Proactive planning

Get ahead of applications: set your standards before projects arrive, avoid controversy, and keep your board in control of siting instead of reacting under pressure. **Courts reject obstructionism.**



Environmental leadership

Do your part to green the NYS grid, and cut use of the fossil peakers that run on the worst air-quality days. Cleaner local air is a direct benefit to your residents.

IT'S ALREADY WORKING HERE

Solar + BESS in Westchester: Real Results



White Plains Community Solar

6.80 MW solar + 7,056 kWh storage. \$1M annual revenue via a lease-based model with NYPA.



IBM Watson Research Center

5.5 MW carport, 6.5M kWh/yr, 85 EV chargers. Subscribed employees save ~10% a month.



Croton-Harmon Train Station

4.2 MW canopies + 3.5 MW BESS + 24 EV chargers. \$480K annual lease, offsets 400 homes.



Vail GMC, Bedford Hills microgrid

75% peak demand reduction, 84% cost savings. Monthly bill fell from \$49K to \$7,840.



GHP Office Realty, Harrison

375 kW / 940 kWh battery earning \$75,000 in annual revenue on shared savings, zero upfront.



Regeneron, Tarrytown

550 kW solar carport deploying clean energy onsite while supporting high-demand operations.

Demand response works here too: Sustainable Westchester GridRewards has ~1,000 MW of peak reduction pledged and 100,000+ Con Edison customers enrolled. The average residential user earned \$80; New Rochelle earned over \$100,000.

ADDRESSING CONCERNS

NYS Standards: Rigorous & Multi-Layered

State fire & building codes

NY's updated rules require pre-construction review, fire department coordination, emergency response plans, and firefighter training

National safety standards

UL 9540 certification, UL 9540A fire testing, and NFPA 855 installation standards before equipment is deployed

Local review

Your board sets siting, setbacks, screening, and operating conditions

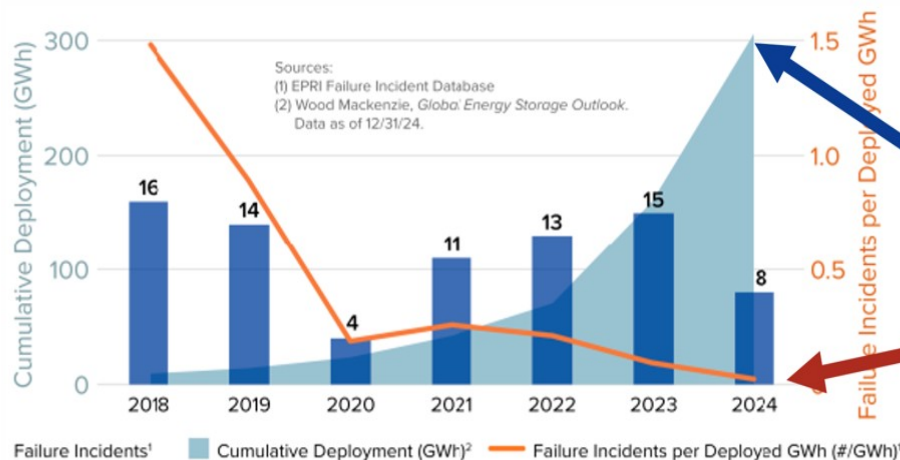
NY's fire code requires:

- ✓ Pre-construction review
- ✓ Fire department coordination
- ✓ Emergency response plans
- ✓ Firefighter training
- ✓ Trained experts on call for any incident

Plus: trained experts must be accessible if an incident occurs, and responders receive BESS-specific training.

ADDRESSING CONCERNS

The Technology Is Proven and Safe.



This chart illustrates the year over year INCREASE in BESS installations, and the significant DECREASE in failure incidents occurring in tandem.

Global BESS deployment vs. failure incident rate. Data: EPRI Failure Incident Database and Wood Mackenzie via EPA, as of 12/31/24. Via the CEAC Fire & Safety Factsheet.

Layered protections are built in:

- ✓ Battery management systems keep cells in safe temperature ranges, and can catch thermal runaway 50 to 80 cycles early
- ✓ Smoke, heat, and gas detection with automatic shutoff and 24/7 remote monitoring
- ✓ Steel fire-rated enclosures, firewalls, and spacing between units
- ✓ Emergency procedures pre-planned with local fire departments

Only 11% of faults trace to the battery cell itself. 65% stem from improper operation and integration, exactly what training, codes, and inspections address.

All Forms of Energy Entail Risk.

No energy infrastructure is risk-free. The question is which risks are managed, and how well.

Two New York incidents, compared:



2014 East Harlem gas explosion

Leaking gas pipeline. Two buildings destroyed instantly. 8 deaths, 50+ injuries.



2023 Warwick, NY BESS Incident

Manufacturing defect in two battery units. Fire contained on site, no injuries, and air monitoring showed toxin levels below harmful thresholds.

Every year, on average, the US experiences:

125,000 gas leaks (22,000 in NYC alone)

286 oil pipeline incidents

27,900 home heating fires

167,800 home cooking fires

Together: 254 deaths, 3,084 injuries, and \$2.5B+ in damage from fossil fuel systems, every year.

Importantly, the battery and format of this facility is longer protocol for modern BESS.
Due to modern state BESS standards that are already in place now, this failure could not happen today.

WHAT WE RECOMMEND

Adopt a Common Sense BESS Law, Not a Ban.



Croton-on-Hudson's law is the model.

A proven Westchester law built on the NYSEDA model. Adopt it as your starting point, and we can help you customize it for your community. Blanket bans block well-designed projects and all their benefits.



It works here already

Croton-on-Hudson, Elmsford, and Tarrytown have working BESS codes. Croton-Harmon Station runs 4.2 MW solar + 3.5 MW BESS today.

Responsible review beats prohibition.

Your code can require project-specific detail on:

- ✓ Equipment & safety testing
- ✓ Site layout & setbacks
- ✓ Emergency response plans
- ✓ Fencing & landscaping
- ✓ Noise & visual screening
- ✓ Stormwater management
- ✓ Operating conditions
- ✓ Decommissioning plans

Our Resources & Support



Fact-centered materials for residents

Plain-language go sheet with talking points on safety, siting, fire department access, screening, and finances, plus our Energy Storage Fire & Safety Factsheet. Printable handouts for your community.



Technical assistance

Field experts available to advise your board and staff on code language, siting, and engineering questions.



Attendance at public meetings

CEAC legal, engineering, and fire-safety experts can present and answer questions at your hearings.



Empowering you to lead

Model documents, peer connections with neighboring municipalities, and ongoing support so boards can act with confidence.

